

Q I've been taking the pill—but I'm pregnant. Will my baby be OK?

The risks to your baby are low. If you are on the pill or minipill, stop taking it if your pregnancy test is positive—you don't need to finish the cycle.

It's understandable that you may not have been aware you are pregnant for a while. Some of the side effects of this form of contraception, such as feeling nauseous and having tender breasts, can also be early pregnancy symptoms. The results of a pregnancy test won't be affected by the pill since the test only reacts to hCG readings.

Try not to worry, but take action immediately to stop whatever type of contraception you are using, as outlined in the chart, right. The hormones in the pill don't last long in your system and trials indicate that there isn't an increase in the risk of birth defects. There is, however, a slightly greater chance of an ectopic pregnancy (see p.308); the minipill can alter the motility of the fallopian tube—affecting the ability of an egg to move through it.

Make an appointment to see your doctor as soon as you can to let him or her know that you are pregnant and that you conceived while you were taking a contraceptive pill. Your doctor can do an ultrasound to rule out an ectopic pregnancy.

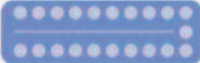
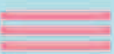


Did you know...

Some couples rely on the withdrawal method as a form of contraception. This is when the man pulls his penis out of the woman before he ejaculates. While this can be effective for some couples who are adept in the method, it shouldn't be relied upon to prevent pregnancy. Some experts claim that preejaculate can pick up sperm that's in the man's urethra from a previous ejaculation, which can lead to pregnancy.

CONTRACEPTION FAILURES AND EFFECTS

While some types of contraception are more effective than others, no single type is a foolproof barrier to pregnancy. This table explains what to do if your contraception has failed.

TYPE OF CONTRACEPTION	WHAT DOES IT DO?	HOW SHOULD I STOP?
Combined pill 	Contains estrogen and progestogen. Estrogen inhibits ovulation and progestogen thickens cervical mucus to make it difficult for a sperm to reach an egg and an egg to implant in the uterus.	Stop taking the pills right away. There is no need to finish the cycle.
Minipill 	Contains just progestogen, not estrogen. The progestogen thickens cervical mucus to make it difficult for a sperm to reach an egg and an egg to implant in the uterus.	Stop taking the pills right away. There is no need to finish the cycle.
Emergency contraceptive pill (also called the morning after pill) 	Works by preventing or delaying ovulation.	Do not take any more emergency contraception.
Injections 	Contains progestogen, which thickens cervical mucus to make it difficult for a sperm to reach an egg and an egg to implant in the uterus.	Simply stop renewing your injections.
Implants 	Inserted under the skin of your upper arm, the flexible tube slowly releases progestogen to stop sperm from reaching an egg and the uterus from supporting a fertilized egg.	A specially trained doctor will need to remove the implant, and an ultrasound may be necessary to locate it.
IUD 	Positioned in the uterus, it prevents a sperm and egg, or a fertilized egg, from implanting in the uterus or fallopian tubes.	There is a risk of miscarriage and ectopic pregnancy because of the presence of a foreign body in the uterus, possible inflammation, and an increased risk of infection. If the IUD is visible, it's best for a specialist to remove it; if not, it is best left where it is for the pregnancy.
Spermicide 	Available in different forms (including gels and foams), spermicide contains chemicals that stop sperm from moving.	Do not use once you are pregnant.
Sterilization	The fallopian tubes are tied to prevent an egg from reaching the uterus.	N/A